

people do it for monetary gain, others because it's "their job." But we also do it without such intentions—spontaneously.

Why? The answer has to do with human nature. Planning may come with the package of what makes us human, namely, our consciousness.

There is supposed to be an evolutionary dimension to our need to project matters into the future, which I will rapidly summarize here, since it can be an excellent candidate explanation, an excellent conjecture, though, since it is linked to evolution, I would be cautious.

The idea, as promoted by the philosopher Daniel Dennett, is as follows: What is the most potent use of our brain? It is precisely the ability to project conjectures into the future and play the counterfactual game—"If I punch him in the nose, then he will punch me back right away, or, worse, call his lawyer in New York." One of the advantages of doing so is that we can let our conjectures die in our stead. Used correctly and in place of more visceral reactions, the ability to project effectively frees us from immediate, first-order natural selection—as opposed to more primitive organisms that were vulnerable to death and only grew by the improvement in the gene pool through the selection of the best. In a way, projecting allows us to cheat evolution: it now takes place in our head, as a series of projections and counterfactual scenarios.

This ability to mentally play with conjectures, even if it frees us from the laws of evolution, is itself supposed to be the product of evolution—it is as if evolution has put us on a long leash whereas other animals live on the very short leash of immediate dependence on their environment. For Dennett, our brains are "anticipation machines;" for him the human mind and consciousness are emerging properties, those properties necessary for our accelerated development.

Why do we listen to experts and their forecasts? A candidate explanation is that society reposes on specialization, effectively the division of knowledge. You do not go to medical school the minute you encounter a big health problem; it is less taxing (and certainly safer) for you to consult someone who has already done so. Doctors listen to car mechanics (not for health matters, just when it comes to problems with their cars); car mechanics listen to doctors. We have a natural tendency to listen to the expert, even in fields where there may be no experts.

* Most of the debate between creationists and evolutionary theorists (of which I do not partake) lies in the following: creationists believe that the world comes from some form of design while evolutionary theorists see the world as a result of random changes by an aimless process. But it is hard to look at a computer or a car and consider them the result of aimless process. Yet they are.

* Recall from [Chapter 4](#) how Algazel and Averroës traded insults through book titles. Perhaps one day I will be lucky enough to read an attack on this book in a diatribe called *The White Swan*.